

Fulbright Scholars



SUMMARY

Where did I first see it—was it in the Strand in London? I recall an exhibit of photos depicting various newsworthy events. I don't remember why, but it caught my attention. A photo of the incoming Fulbright Scholars, now arriving or recently arrived in England. Some of them, anyway. Were you in that photo? I looked at it, not all that closely, curious as to which of the people in it I might meet. I recall having that thought. I don't recall seeing your face. I'm sure I must have taken special care to look at each of the girls. Perhaps I did see you there. Perhaps I looked you up and down, felt unworthy. Saw your long, wavy hair, your fringe styled like the actress Veronica Lake's—but not what the fringe concealed. Your hair would have looked blond. And your smile—your over-the-top, American smile aimed at the news cameras, the scholarship judges, people you didn't know, people who scared you. Then I forgot all about it. But now I remember it: the photo of the Fulbright Scholars. Were they carrying their luggage? That doesn't seem right. Is it possible they all arrived together? I was strolling with aching feet on a hot day, on hot sidewalks—was that when I stopped to buy a peach? That's what I recollect. I bought it from a vendor near Charing Cross Station. It was the first time I'd ever eaten a fresh peach. I was blown away by how amazing it tasted. I was twenty-five years old and astonished all over again by my inexperience in even the most basic areas.

photograph, but equivocates about what he does and doesn't remember—suggesting that memory itself is unreliable. He questions where he saw the photograph—"the Strand?" (a main road in London)—later concluding that he *does* remember "a stall near Charing Cross Station," which is on the Strand. In other words, he seems not to remember, then does. He shows the same uncertainty regarding Plath, probing his memory for whether she was "among" the other "Fulbright scholars" in the photo. He says he didn't look closely, and that he doesn't remember seeing his future wife's face—but if he did, he says (contradicting himself), he would have noticed how beautiful she was. Of course, there's no way he can know whether he's remembering her beauty from the photo or whether he's just superimposing later knowledge onto it. And that's the point: memory is tricky and can't be entirely trusted.

Hughes then emphasizes his "ignorance" as a young man, suggesting that experience and hindsight might have reshaped his memory of the event. He says that "At twenty-five [he] was dumbfounded" (astonished) by his "ignorance of the simplest things." By drawing attention to his youthful naïveté, he hints at the unreliability of his own memories. His perceptions at the time were colored by ignorance; his memories now are colored by the knowledge he's acquired since. For instance, he recalls Plath's "Veronica Lake bang" (a sideswept hairstyle that obscured one eye, popularized by American actress Veronica Lake), knowing he would have been drawn to it without knowing "what it hid." Hughes is referring to a scar that a previous suicide attempt had left on Plath's forehead; she chose her hairstyle in part to cover the scar. This detail perfectly illustrates the vast difference between Hughes' initial perceptions of her and the reality he came to know later.

So hindsight is not necessarily 20/20: in fact, later experience can make it hard to recover the original truth of events. And these aren't just any events Hughes is writing about: he's reflecting on one of the most infamous literary marriages of all time. Hughes faced intense media scrutiny and accusations of abuse; many people considered him responsible for Plath's suicide. By claiming uncertainty about these events from the start, Hughes perhaps makes a case for viewing their relationship—as well as Plath's death and his role in it—in a less black-and-white manner. Things that once seemed simple become complicated with accrued knowledge and experience.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-29



THEMES



NAÏVETÉ, HINDSIGHT, AND MEMORY

In "Fulbright Scholars," Ted Hughes recalls a photograph he saw when he was "twenty-five." It featured a group of scholarship students arriving in London, one of whom—the American poet Sylvia Plath—he would later marry. At the time, this picture stoked his curiosity, but it held no personal significance for him, so he soon "forgot" it. Years later, after his marriage to Plath ended in her tragic suicide, he has reason to "remember" this long-forgotten first glimpse of her. He knows she must have stood out to him, that even in a picture she must have appeared as striking as he would later find her in person. Yet in hindsight, he realizes the photograph couldn't have revealed what her physical attributes "hid": the mental illness that would eventually steal her life, and the devastation that would follow. The poem, which is addressed to Plath, thus illustrates the instability of memory, which shifts and deepens with time and experience.

Hughes recalls first seeing his future wife, Plath, in a



APPEARANCE, REALITY, AND GENDER

As well as the deceptions of memory, "Fulbright Scholars" points to the deceptiveness of appearance.

In recalling his first impressions of Sylvia Plath's outer beauty, Hughes acknowledges (or *confesses*—a word important to Plath's poetry!) that he had no idea what was going on underneath. The poem thus stands as a warning against judging people in general—and perhaps complicated artists like Plath in particular—based on initial, superficial readings. It also implies that "ignorant" young men are especially likely to judge women on a superficial basis, in ways they may drastically rethink or regret later.

Hughes's first impressions reflect not only the naiveté but the *superficiality* of youth, and of young men especially. He admits that when he first "scanned" the photo of the Fulbright Scholars, it was to take note of "the girls." He knows that if he noticed Plath at all, it was because he saw her as beautiful and unattainable, due to the "loose waves" of her "blond" hair, her "exaggerated American / Grin," and so on. In other words, he knows now that she would have "appear[ed]" attractive, fashionable, and confident. So his interest in her was skin-deep: he was simply drawn to the way she looked.

But Plath was far more than she appeared, and his "ignorant" superficiality seems to cause him regret later. Attraction is simple; Hughes' and Plath's marriage was anything but. They fell in love at lightning speed and married four months after they met. When the speaker describes "the first fresh peach [he] had ever tasted," then, this peach seems to [symbolize](#) the "delicious[ness]" of his relationship with Plath in their honeymoon phase. But in reality, they didn't yet know each other beyond their surface attraction. His nostalgia for his "delicious" whirlwind romance with Plath gives way to his confession that, "At twenty-five," he was "ignorant" of the simplest things. He's hinting that he believed he knew Plath when he married her—that he *could* know someone deeply after only four months together. It wasn't until he got to know the real Plath, with whom he shared a tumultuous six-year relationship, that he understood how shallow and incomplete his first perceptions were.

And the poem implies that these miscalculations had a lot to do with gender. As a young man, Hughes was socialized to see women as objects, and thus to take them at face value. Plath was beautiful, stylish, and charming, but beneath the surface, she was also a deeply complex person fighting her own difficult battles. Getting to know her better before marriage might have saved them both a world of hurt.

Broadly, then, the poem cautions against relying too heavily on our first impressions of others, since appearances can deceive and people often carry burdens that don't meet the eye.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 11-18
- Lines 24-29



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*Where was it, ...
... some of them.*

"Fulbright Scholars" is the first poem in Hughes's final poetry collection, *Birthday Letters*, which deals primarily with his marriage to the American poet Sylvia Plath. This marriage was intense and complicated; it ended with Hughes's infidelity, and Plath, who struggled with mental illness, died by suicide not long after. Hughes made very few public statements regarding her death or his role in it until the publication of *Birthday Letters*.

The poem begins with Hughes posing a question: "Where was it, in the Strand?" This question drops the reader right into his thought process, as if he were already in the middle of remembering something. In order to find out what he's referring to (what "it" is), the reader has to continue on to the second line. [Enjambment](#) across lines 1 and 2 helps pull the reader into the poem:

Where was it, in the Strand? A display
Of news items, in photographs.

So the speaker is recalling a group of photographs, one of which grabbed his attention. It was "A picture of that year's intake / Of Fulbright Scholars." This refers to the Fulbright Scholarship, a program that allows students from the United States to attend graduate school in other countries. Hughes met Plath while she was in England on a Fulbright, so it starts to become clear why this memory holds significance for him.

Hughes says that the people in the photo were "Just arriving— / Or arrived. Or some of them." [Polyptoton](#) (the [repetition](#) of "arriving"/"arrived") and [anaphora](#) (the repetition of "Or") creates a hesitant, stammering effect, highlighting his uncertainty about what the photo was actually showing. Were these students all just getting off a plane, or had they each arrived separately and were now meeting up to take the picture? His equivocation suggests the slipperiness of memory, and his desire now to pin down what he actually saw (or what the truth of the photo was). His self-revisions also suggest that memory is altered by later perceptions and knowledge; the photo stays the same, but his understanding of what he saw evolves.

From these opening lines, it's clear that the poem is written in [free verse](#). Instead of following a set [meter](#) or [rhyme scheme](#), it

sounds natural, casual, and true to how people think (or think aloud). It contains no [stanza](#) breaks, either; it all runs together into a single block of text, perhaps evoking the way memories blur together with later feelings and perceptions. The poem's short, often fragmentary sentences and frequent [caesuras](#) create a choppy rhythm, which also helps convey the speaker's uncertainty. These aren't fluid, confident statements but cautious assertions that quickly break off and turn on themselves. All of these effects suggest that Hughes doesn't entirely trust his own memory regarding this photo—which didn't seem all that important when he first saw it, but has come to seem fateful with time.

LINES 7-12

*Were you among ...
... The girls.*

In line 7, the poem shifts into an [apostrophe](#). Hughes directly addresses Plath, his long-dead wife, asking her if she was "among" the other Fulbright Scholars in the photo. Apostrophe makes the poem feel more intimate, as if it isn't meant for an audience. Of course, since Plath wasn't alive to read the poem, it wasn't really meant for her, either—Hughes is only addressing his memory of her.

He says he didn't look all that "minutely" (closely) at the photo, which is why he's having trouble remembering whether Plath was in it. What he does remember is "wondering / which of [the people in the photo he] might meet." That he remembers what he was thinking at the time, but not Plath's "face," simply reflects the fact that he hadn't met her yet. Only now, years after meeting her, falling for her, marrying her, and losing her, does he look back on this photo and realize it may have been his first glimpse of her.

He says, "No doubt I scanned particularly / the girls," indicating his surface-level interest in the photograph. He expected to encounter these Fulbright Scholars socially (Hughes was a Cambridge student at the time), so he just wanted to see if there were any especially beautiful women he might meet.

A mix of [end-stopped](#) and [enjambéd](#) lines, short sentences, and frequent [caesuras](#) create the poem's distinctive rhythm:

Which of them I might meet.
I remember that thought. Not
Your face. No doubt I scanned particularly
The girls. [...]

The speaker's statements are abrupt, fragmented, and frequently interrupted by questions. All those caesuras and enjambments make the rhythm feel choppy—not smooth and flowing, like someone relaxing into their memories, but unsettled, like someone trying to figure something out. It seems as if the speaker is struggling to be precise and truthful about something blurry and uncertain.

LINES 12-15

*Maybe I noticed ...
... what it hid.*

In lines 12-13, Hughes continues to [apostrophize](#) Plath, again in a hesitant, uncertain [tone](#):

[...] Maybe I noticed you.
Maybe I weighed you up, feeling unlikely.

In other words, he can't recall definitively whether she was in the photo or not, and whether he took note of her or not. If he did, he admits he would have been "weigh[ing] up" (or measuring) her physical beauty, against which he would have felt "unlikely," or insufficient. In other words, if he had noticed her, it would have been because she was attractive—he wouldn't have thought he'd have stood a chance with her. But the [repetition](#) of "Maybe" again stresses that he doesn't actually remember her face in the photo, and that he's projecting later events onto this possible first encounter with her. When he eventually met her in person, he was bowled over by her beauty and vibrancy, but it's quite possible that he overlooked her in the photo.

He goes on to describe, however, what he would have paid attention to if he *had* noticed Plath: her "long hair" and "loose waves," and her "Veronica Lake bang" (or fringe). Veronica Lake was a famous American actress who wore her hair parted to the side, where it cascaded over one eye, creating a peek-a-boo effect that many found alluring. Hughes clearly liked the way Plath wore her hair, not knowing at the time that it had a practical purpose as well as an aesthetic one: it "hid" the scar on her forehead from a previous suicide attempt. Plath was ashamed of this scar; it served as a permanent reminder of the psychological distress that led her to hurt herself. The subtle reference to Plath's scar sets up a contrast between her glamorous appearance and her inner struggles, which were not immediately apparent to Hughes.

Throughout lines 13-15, caesuras continue to create a clipped, unsettled rhythm:

Maybe I weighed you up, feeling unlikely.
Noted your long hair, loose waves—
Your Veronica Lake bang. Not what it hid.

The full stop after "bang" is particularly dramatic. As it splits the line in two, it highlights the gap between Plath's beautiful exterior and "hid[den]," troubled interior. [Asyndeton](#) (the lack of conjunctions between "long hair," "loose waves," and "Your Veronica Lake bang") makes the language sound all the more terse and fragmentary. Once again, the hesitations reflect Hughes's struggle to pin down his first impressions of Plath.

LINES 16-18

*It would appear ...
... strangers, the frighteners.*

Hughes continues to probe his memory, imagining his first glimpse of Plath even though he can't recall if she was actually in the Fulbright photo. He knows her hair would have "appear[ed] blond" at the time, and he can vividly picture her smile:

[...] And your grin.
Your exaggerated American
Grin for the cameras, the judges, the strangers, the
frighteners.

In other words, he knows that Plath would have had a huge, convincing smile plastered to her face, because Plath knew how to put on a performance for people. As a woman coming from 1950s America, she was expected to always look amazing and to appear bright, bubbly, and happy. And Plath was good at meeting these expectations; she excelled in school, won prizes, and played the part of the charming, cheerful girlfriend. But on the inside, she grappled with constant fear and anxiety, feelings of despair and worthlessness. You couldn't see the whole of her from looking at a photograph. The [repetition](#) of "grin" in lines 16 and 18 emphasizes what Hughes would have seen, as opposed to what might have been going on inside Plath's head. Looking back, he knows that if he did see her face among the other Fulbright Scholars, he would only have seen that beautiful, vivacious exterior—not the things that hurt and tormented her.

Note the long sentence [enjambéd](#) across lines 17-18:

Your exaggerated American
Grin for the cameras, the judges, the strangers, the
frighteners.

The enjambment emphasizes "American," the word just before the [line break](#), and thus calls attention to Plath's Americanness. (The U.S./UK culture divide would become both a source of attraction and a source of tension in the Plath-Hughes relationship.) The unusual length of line 18, with its pile-up of [parallel](#) clauses ("the cameras, the judges," etc.), helps convey how overwhelmed and even "frighten[ed]" Plath felt at the time. Though the young Hughes would have noticed only Plath's beauty and confidence, the older Hughes recognizes the immense strain Plath was under—as a woman and, more specifically, a woman struggling with mental illness.

LINES 19-23

*Then I forgot. ...
... sun, hot pavements.*

After seeing the Fulbright Scholars photograph, Hughes says,

he quickly "forgot" it. Since he didn't know anyone in the photo, it was only of passing interest, and as soon as he walked away, it receded from his mind. Yet he seems to "remember" it now, all these years later, because it might have been the first time he saw Plath's face. Line 19 sums up the contradiction: "Then I forgot. Yet I remember [...]"

If he does remember, he remembers imperfectly. He vaguely recalls noticing and thinking about the photo, but he can't clearly conjure up the details. He tries to recall if the "Fulbright Scholars" had "their luggage" with them in the photo, if they arrived "as a team." He decides this is "unlikely." His attempt to pinpoint the truth of the photo is really about his desire to pinpoint the truth of his relationship with Plath. He wants to remember things correctly, as they were, not tinged by the bitterness of loss and grief. But there is no way for him to remember the photo objectively, because memory is shaped by time and experience. Thus the photo comes to [symbolize](#) a past he can't fully access; he can only see things through his current understanding of what transpired.

He again turns back to what he does remember: that he was "walking / Sore-footed, under hot sun, hot pavements." This part of the memory is less blurry, perhaps because his walk in the heat has taken on no additional significance over time. It's the most emotionally charged memories, the poem implies, that are most likely to morph along with us.

LINES 24-27

*Was it then ...
... believe how delicious.*

"Was it then I bought a peach?" the speaker asks, and immediately answers his [rhetorical question](#): "That's as I remember." He says he got the peach from a vendor "near Charing Cross Station," which is in the Strand in London. It's possible he's conflating two different experiences because they occurred close together; he might actually have bought the peach the same day he looked at the photo, or he might have come to associate the fruit with the photo for other reasons. He claims that "It was the first fresh peach I had ever tasted," and that he "could hardly believe how delicious" it was.

The /f/ [alliteration](#) here ("first fresh") draws attention to the novelty and excitement of the experience. His enchantment with the peach seems to [symbolize](#) his early romance with Plath: she, too, seemed "fresh," vibrant, and totally outside the realm of his experience. The two fell in love instantly—or at least felt a strong chemistry that he, as a young man, believed was love. (It's worth noting that Hughes and Plath married after only four months.)

The peach also has sensual [connotations](#) (due to their shape, freshness, fleshiness, etc., peaches are often used as sexual symbols). Hughes and Plath kissed fervently the first time they met, and the encounter made a lasting impression on them both. Though he doesn't say it explicitly, Hughes might be

wondering how much of the intensity of their relationship was sexual, and how much pain they might have spared themselves if they had been free to explore that connection without the pressure to marry.

Finally, the peach may [allude](#) to T.S. Eliot's poem "[The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock](#)," whose hero expresses sexual desire—and a desire to live more spontaneously—through the famous question, "Do I dare to eat a peach?" The "delicious[ness]" of Hughes' initial relationship with Plath derived in part from its daring, sensuality, and spontaneity. Hughes clearly took great joy in their early days together, but the poem implicitly asks at what cost.

LINES 28-29

*At twenty-five I ...
... the simplest things.*

In the poem's final lines, Hughes turns his enjoyment of that "first fresh peach" into a kind of moral lesson: "At twenty-five I was dumbfounded afresh / By my ignorance of the simplest things." In other words, Hughes recalls feeling astonished, while tasting a juicy peach on a hot day in London, that he'd never experienced that pleasure before. Though he probably already thought of himself as worldly-wise, he realized, in that moment, that there were still countless things he had to learn.

Of course, he's now applying this realization to his relationship with Plath. Writing this poem, he's much older and wiser than he was when he dove headfirst into a marriage with someone he barely knew. He's now able to acknowledge how "ignorant[t]" he was, how rash and irresponsible with his own and another's heart. That taste of the "fresh peach" wasn't the first or the last time he'd be stunned by his naïveté.

The conclusion suggests that he accepts a certain amount of responsibility for the way things ended with Plath. He's implicitly admitting that he failed her in certain ways; in his youthful inexperience, he made mistakes that couldn't be rectified. But he also implies that these weren't errors of malevolence, only of "ignorance." In other words, he didn't really understand what he was getting into when he married Plath, because he didn't understand how long it takes to get to know someone well. He admits that he was young and shallow when he met her, and didn't appreciate the full depth of her being. Still, he doesn't go so far as to accept all the accusations directed at him during his life. Indeed, while the poem is primarily a personal exploration, it also implicitly asks readers and critics—both his and Plath's—to treat their work and lives with more nuance and compassion.



SYMBOLS



THE PHOTOGRAPH

Over the course of the poem, the photograph of the Fulbright Scholars comes to [symbolize](#) the emptiness of appearances, since photos show only how people look in one moment, not how they are in general. What's more, the photo Hughes is recalling wouldn't have been a candid one; everyone in it was posing and smiling for the camera. Plath's "exaggerated [...] / Grin" likely had more to do with the expectations of the photographer, and the people who would see the photo, than with her actual feelings at the time. In this way, the poem suggests that it's silly to judge people based on superficial impressions; really knowing someone takes time.

Photographs are also unlike memories in that they're static; they never change. Memory, on the other hand, morphs with time and understanding. Thus, the photo also seems to represent those aspects of the past which Hughes can't fully access anymore, because he's too far removed from them.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "A display / Of news items, in photographs."
- **Lines 4-5:** "A picture of that year's intake / Of Fulbright Scholars."
- **Lines 19-20:** "Yet I remember / The picture"



THE PEACH

The "peach" that Hughes recalls eating, on the day he first saw Sylvia Plath in a photo, seems to [symbolize](#) his overall relationship with Plath. Reflecting on his youthful "ignorance," he claims that this was "the first fresh peach [he] had ever tasted." This suggests that when he met Plath, he was young and naïve. He had never experienced anything like the romance they went on to share, just as he'd never tasted fruit that "delicious." The peach might even harken back to the forbidden fruit that Adam and Eve taste, bringing an end to their innocence.

In its associations with sweetness, fleshiness, etc., the peach also hints at the intense sexual chemistry that drew Plath and Hughes together. (This is a well-established trope in English poetry; for example, the hero of T. S. Eliot's "[The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock](#)" famously asks "Do I dare to eat a peach?" as a coded way of expressing his sexual anxieties.) Hughes and Plath met at a party where they were immediately attracted to each other. They yelled back and forth over the noise, discussing each other's poetry, then Hughes kissed her so forcefully that Plath bit his cheek in response, drawing blood. This encounter shook them both up, and they married only four months later.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 24-29:** "Was it then I bought a peach? That's as I remember. / From a stall near Charing Cross Station. / It was the first fresh peach I had ever tasted. / I could hardly believe how delicious. / At twenty-five I was dumbfounded afresh / By my ignorance of the simplest things."

**POETIC DEVICES****REPETITION**

Various kinds of [repetition](#) contribute rhythm and emphasis to the poem. Lines 5-7, for example, contain [polyptoton](#), [anaphora](#), and [epistrophe](#):

Of Fulbright Scholars. Just arriving—
Or arrived. Or some of them.
Were you among **them**? I studied it,

Polyptoton (the repetition of "arriving"/"arrived") highlights the speaker's uncertainty about whether the people in the photo were all just landing in London, or whether their arrivals had been staggered. Though this detail isn't particularly important—what does it matter to the speaker when these strangers arrived?—it helps reveal his overall lack of clarity. He starts with an assumption—that they're all just now arriving—then quickly questions that assumption, wondering if perhaps he got it wrong. A similar uncertainty surrounds other assumptions he made as a young man, including his superficial judgements about his future wife.

Anaphora (the repetition of "Or") also highlights the speaker's reassessment or revision of his memories. Both anaphora and epistrophe (the repetition of "them") add to the choppy rhythm of the passage, which, in turn, reflects the way Hughes's mind shifts directions and tries to home in on the truth.

More anaphora follows in lines 12-13:

The girls. **Maybe** I noticed you.
Maybe I weighed you up, feeling unlikely.

The repetition here again emphasizes the speaker's uncertainty: he isn't saying that he clearly remembers seeing Plath in this photo, only that he might have. If he did, he would have felt intimidated by her beauty and Americanness, which would have seemed glossy, "exaggerated," and foreign to a young man from the British countryside.

Later, line 18 contains repetition across a series of [parallel](#) clauses:

Grin for **the** cameras, **the** judges, **the** strangers, **the**

frighteners.

Here, repetition builds rhythm and momentum, intensifying the speaker's statement. This intensity reflects Plath's anxiety about having to perform for everyone—a pressure she eventually buckled under. That she was "frighten[ed]" by the flashbulbs, "judges," and "strangers" is something Hughes understands in retrospect; at the time, he only saw her bright "Grin," not guessing what it concealed.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 5:** "arriving"
- **Line 6:** "Or," "arrived," "Or," "them"
- **Line 7:** "them"
- **Line 12:** "Maybe I"
- **Line 13:** "Maybe I"
- **Line 18:** "the," "the," "the"

ENJAMBMENT

While most of the poem's lines are [end-stopped](#), occasional [enjambment](#) helps keep the poem's pacing dynamic.

In fact, the first line of the poem is enjambed, helping to draw the reader into the poem:

Where was it, the Strand? A **display**
Of news items, in photographs.

Hughes begins the poem with a question, but rather than ending the first line there, he begins the next sentence, describing what it is he's trying to place in his memories. The reader has to keep going in order to find out what was in the "display," and thus gets pulled into the world of the poem.

There are several enjambments in lines 8-12:

Not too minutely, **wondering**
Which of them I might meet.
I remember that thought. **Not**
Your face. No doubt I scanned **particularly**
The girls. Maybe I noticed you.

The enjambment here is in tension with the frequent caesuras; while the one creates momentum, pulling the reader from one line to the next, the other slows the pace of the language. The result is a choppy rhythm that evokes the mind's movement as it calibrates and re-calibrates, trying to draw a bead on perceptions that have changed with time.

In lines 17-18, enjambment adds to the momentum and intensity of Hughes' description of Plath:

Your exaggerated **American**
Grin for the cameras, the judges, the strangers, the

frighteners.

This is one of the longest sentences in the poem, and enjambment makes it feel more breathless—perhaps echoing Plath's exhaustion at constantly having to live up to people's expectations. The enjambment also highlights the word before the [line break](#), "American," which hints at a culture clash between the American Plath and the English Hughes.

Another long sentence occurs at the end of the poem, and is also enjambed across two lines:

At twenty-five I was dumbfounded afresh
By my ignorance of the simplest things.

Coming after a long series of end-stops, this enjambment makes the statement feel more expansive, like a sudden breakthrough. It's as if the speaker is freshly realizing how naive he was at that age.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "display / Of"
- **Lines 4-5:** "intake / Of"
- **Lines 8-9:** "wondering / Which"
- **Lines 10-11:** "Not / Your"
- **Lines 11-12:** "particularly / The"
- **Lines 17-18:** "American / Grin"
- **Lines 19-20:** "remember / The"
- **Lines 22-23:** "walking / Sore-footed"
- **Lines 28-29:** "afresh / By"

CAESURA

The poem's many [caesuras](#), combined with its short sentences and frequent [asyndeton](#), give its language an abrupt, choppy rhythm. This rhythm is important, as it evokes the speaker's hesitancy and changes of mind as he tries to navigate old memories. The abruptness also helps rein in the speaker's emotions even as the poem touches on highly charged subject matter.

Look at the caesuras in the opening lines, for example:

Where was it, in the Strand? A display
Of news items, in photographs.

Each pause or hesitation seems to help Hughes refine his memories. He starts with a vague question—"Where was it"—then immediately recalls that it must have been "in the Strand." After another pause, he retrieves a visual memory: "A display / Of news items," which he then specifies were "in photographs." In this way, caesura helps evoke the speaker's mind at work, the twists and turns of his thought as he journeys into the past.

Caesura also helps to evoke his uncertainty, as he constantly interrupts himself to question his assumptions. Take lines 5-6:

Of Fulbright Scholars. Just arriving—
Or arrived. Or some of them.

After the first caesura, he's expanding on the memory by specifying that the scholars were just arriving from abroad. Yet he immediately revises himself, suggesting that maybe they had "arrived" earlier. The next caesura (after "arrived") marks another recalculation, as he realizes that some of the Fulbright Scholars probably weren't in this picture. Again and again, he realizes that there are things he got wrong in his initial perceptions—much as he did with Plath herself.

In lines 15-16, caesura helps highlight the gap between his first impression of his soon-to-be-wife and his current understanding of who she was underneath:

Your Veronica Lake bang. Not what it hid.
It would appear blond. And your grin.

The full stop after "bang" sets up the striking contrast between Plath's glamorous exterior and her troubled interior (her hairstyle "hid" a scar on her forehead from a previous suicide attempt).

Again, both this caesura and the one after "blond" contribute to the poem's brisk, clipped, fragmentary style. ("Not what it hid" and "And your grin" are both sentence fragments.) This style might hint at the way Plath cut her life short; it also creates a tightly controlled, clenched [tone](#) that suggests Hughes' own residual pain over these events.

Where Caesura appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "it, in," "Strand? A"
- **Line 2:** "items, in"
- **Line 5:** "Scholars. Just"
- **Line 6:** "arrived. Or"
- **Line 7:** "them? I"
- **Line 8:** "minutely, wondering"
- **Line 10:** "thought. Not"
- **Line 11:** "face. No"
- **Line 12:** "girls. Maybe"
- **Line 13:** "up, feeling"
- **Line 14:** "hair, loose"
- **Line 15:** "bang. Not"
- **Line 16:** "blond. And"
- **Line 18:** "cameras, the," "judges, the," "strangers, the"
- **Line 19:** "forgot. Yet"
- **Line 20:** "picture: the"
- **Line 21:** "luggage? It"
- **Line 22:** "team? I"
- **Line 23:** "Sore-footed, under," "sun, hot"

- **Line 24:** "peach? That's"

APOSTROPHE

In lines 7-18, Hughes directly [apostrophizes](#) his late wife, the poet Sylvia Plath.

Plath committed suicide in 1963, in a tragedy that shaped the rest of Hughes' life. That he addresses her directly while trying to recall his first impression of her suggests that he's reassessing their relationship—trying to see it clearly and objectively. This is no easy task, considering their tumultuous history and Plath's untimely death, for which many people held Hughes directly or indirectly responsible.

Regardless of whether he saw himself as culpable, the poem suggests that he understands how his treatment of her reflects broader issues: male objectification of women, social pressure on women to conform to certain ideals, and so on. Though Plath had been dead for decades by the time Hughes wrote the poem, it seems he still cared for her, felt he'd failed her, and hoped to understand her better. His apostrophe, then, is that of a grieving and/or guilt-ridden partner reaching out toward the dead.

The device also makes the poem sound more intimate. Hughes isn't just writing about any old memory, after all, but a memory in which he potentially encountered his future wife for the first time. Apostrophe helps evoke the closeness and intensity of this bond, even after many years have passed.

Where Apostrophe appears in the poem:

- **Line 7:** "Were you among them?"
- **Lines 10-11:** "Not / Your face."
- **Lines 12-18:** "Maybe I noticed you. / Maybe I weighed you up, feeling unlikely. / Noted your long hair, loose waves— / Your Veronica Lake bang. Not what it hid. / It would appear blond. And your grin. / Your exaggerated American / Grin for the cameras, the judges, the strangers, the frighteners."

ALLUSION

In line 15, Hughes [alludes](#) to a scar on Sylvia Plath's forehead, saying that although he would have "Noted" her "Veronica Lake bang" the first time he saw a photo of her, he wouldn't have known what that hairstyle "hid."

Veronica Lake was an American actress who wore her hair parted to the side, with waves covering one eye. It was considered a sultry, teasing look, and clearly Hughes was drawn to it. Yet he didn't know, at the time, that she wore this look in part to disguise a scar on her forehead from her first suicide attempt. (In 1953, she took her mother's sleeping pills and crawled into the crawlspace in their cellar; the scar resulted from her waking, sitting up, and hitting her head.) She was self-

conscious of the scar, both as a blemish and as a reminder of her past attempt at self-annihilation. The allusion suggests the vast gulf between what Hughes saw in Plath at first—her beauty and "exaggerated" confidence—and the reality of who she was.

Lines 24-27 likely allude to T. S. Eliot's poem "[The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock](#)" (1915):

Was it then I bought a peach? That's as I remember.
From a stall near Charing Cross Station.
It was the first fresh peach I had ever tasted.
I could hardly believe how delicious.

This passage echoes the speaker of Eliot's poem, who famously asks, "Do I dare to eat a peach?" This question has been interpreted in various ways; some critics believe it [metaphorically](#) refers to having sex, others to being spontaneous or doing things that are messy or embarrassing. Given that Eliot's speaker also says he is "Almost, at times, the Fool," Hughes' allusion might suggest his own naïveté and folly in rushing into marriage with Plath. His initial impressions of her were so "delicious," the poem implies, that he assumed life with her would be nothing more than a continuation of those first few wonderful months. He now understands this assumption was absurd. There's much more to a person than how they appear, and even strong romantic chemistry doesn't guarantee that a relationship will work long-term.

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Line 15:** "Your Veronica Lake bang. Not what it hid."
- **Lines 24-27:** "Was it then I bought a peach? That's as I remember. / From a stall near Charing Cross Station. / It was the first fresh peach I had ever tasted. / I could hardly believe how delicious."



VOCABULARY

The Strand (Line 1) - A main road in London.

Fulbright Scholars (Lines 4-5, Lines 19-20) - The Fulbright Scholarship is an American cultural exchange program for graduate students.

Minutely (Lines 7-8) - Closely or carefully.

Weighed you up (Line 13) - Looked you up and down; took everything about you into consideration.

Veronica Lake bang (Lines 14-15) - Veronica Lake was an American actress; her distinct hairstyle included a side-swept fringe that covered one eye.

The frighteners (Lines 17-18) - Hughes is suggesting that "the cameras, the judges, [and] the strangers" all scared Plath, making her feel as if she had to put on a performance for them.

Charing Cross Station (Line 25) - A train station at the western end of the Strand in London.

Afresh (Line 28) - All over again.

Dumbfounded (Line 28) - Bewildered or astonished.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Fulbright Scholars" consists of 29 lines of [free verse](#) arranged in a single stanza. The lack of [stanza](#) breaks causes the whole poem to meld together. This fluid structure mirrors the way Hughes's past and present perspectives blur over time, making it hard to distinguish his original experience of the photograph from his current knowledge.

Other formal features help convey Hughes's meaning, too. For example, the many short sentence fragments (e.g., "Just arriving— / Or arrived. Or some of them") give the poem a clipped, hesitant rhythm. This rhythm mirrors Hughes's hedging about memory and truth: he says almost nothing definitive in the poem, instead going back and forth about what he does and doesn't remember.

On the other hand, it's no coincidence that line 18 ("Grin for the cameras, the judges, the strangers, the frighteners") is the longest line in the poem. This line suggests how overwhelmed Plath felt around "cameras" and crowds, so it makes sense that the line itself feels excessive or overloaded compared to the rest of the poem.

METER

The poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't follow a set [meter](#). Indeed, by the time Hughes wrote this poem (which was published in 1998), metered poetry had fallen somewhat out of favor in the professional poetry world. Hughes and his late wife, Sylvia Plath, had played a part in that trend in the 1950s and '60s; Plath's turn away from regular meter toward a looser style marked an important breakthrough in her work.

Here, the relative casualness of free verse gives the poem a conversational, direct tone—which makes sense, given that Hughes is addressing Plath directly. The intimate, informal [tone](#) reflects their former closeness, but it also captures the speaker's current psychological state. He's nostalgically sorting through his own memories, trying to make sense of them. Since Plath is no longer alive to hear him, he's really speaking to himself.

RHYME SCHEME

As a [free verse](#) poem, "Fulbright Scholars" doesn't follow a [rhyme scheme](#). While tightly controlled rhymes create intense musicality, their performative effect would have detracted, here, from the candid and intimate [tone](#) Hughes is aiming for.

The point is for the reader to feel as if they're sharing in the speaker's thoughts, and of course people don't generally *think* in rhymes.

Note that the poet does use [assonance](#) and [consonance](#) to create some subtle, [slant](#) end-rhymes: "hid," "grin," and "American" in lines 15-17 and "frighteners," "remember," and "Scholars" in lines 18-20. As a result, this passage stands out a bit, drawing attention to important [juxtapositions](#) in the poem (Plath's charming personality vs. her troubled inner life and Hughes's claims about remembering vs. forgetting).



SPEAKER

The speaker of "Fulbright Scholars" is Ted Hughes himself. *Birthday Letters*, the collection in which this poem appears, reflects on Hughes's relationship with the American poet Sylvia Plath, to whom he was married for six years. Much of Hughes' poetry was impersonal, so the autobiographical nature of these poems was significant. It suggested to readers that 30 years after Plath's suicide, he was still reflecting on what transpired between them, and what role their relationship played in her death.

"Fulbright Scholars" takes readers all the way back to the start of their relationship—or rather, before it, back when Plath was just a face in a photo of strangers. In the poem, Hughes recalls this photo years later, trying to remember whether he noticed her then and, if so, what he would have observed about her. Sometimes his memory seems clear; other times he contradicts himself or doubts the accuracy of his recollections. By stressing his youthful "ignorance" at the end of the poem, Hughes suggests that he doesn't have all the answers to the questions people confronted him with after Plath died.



SETTING

The poem's [setting](#) is post-World War II London. In it, Hughes recalls a photo he saw when he was 25, meaning that it takes place in 1955, the same year Sylvia Plath arrived in London on a Fulbright scholarship. Hughes remembers noticing a picture of the incoming "Fulbright Scholars"—including, possibly, Plath—in "A display / Of news items [in the Strand]" (a main thoroughfare in London).

He doesn't specially recall whether Plath was in the photo, but if she was, he reckons he would have noticed her chic hair and "Veronica Lake bang." Veronica Lake was a famous American actress whose glamorous waves fell over one eye, giving her a signature peek-a-boo look that Hughes (and many others) clearly found alluring. The period pop culture reference again emphasizes that these events take place in the post-WWII years. It also points to Plath's *Americanness*—which Hughes again highlights in recalling her "exaggerated American /

Grin"—and hints that a U.S./UK cultural divide played into their relationship (as a source of both attraction and conflict).

Though the poem mostly recounts what the poet *doesn't* remember about this photo, he does clearly recall purchasing a "peach" from a vendor near London's "Charing Cross Station." That he remembers the "delicious[ness]" of this peach, more than the details of the photo, underscores the fact that his first glimpse of Plath was just a footnote to an average day. Only later would he realize that it was a crucial moment in his life.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

"Fulbright Scholars" is the first poem in *Birthday Letters*, Ted Hughes's final poetry collection. Published in 1998, shortly before his death, the book focuses on his relationship with his former wife Sylvia Plath, the famous American poet who died by suicide in 1963. Hughes remained largely silent for much of his life when it came to Plath, but *Birthday Letters* tells the story from his perspective, starting with their first meeting and ending with a contemplation of her death.

Hughes wrote the collection over a period of 25 years or so and revised the poems extensively. He acknowledged that their autobiographical content set them apart from his other work, [calling them](#) "so raw, so vulnerable, so unprocessed, so naive, so self-exposing and unguarded." The poems were clearly intended to bring Hughes, if not necessarily his readers, a sense of closure: "I published it purely to get it off my chest and I'm indifferent to its fate," he said. *Birthday Letters* caused a sensation upon publication, with its reception often reflecting the divide between pro-Hughes and pro-Plath readers.

It's notable that Hughes doesn't use "Fulbright Scholars" to make a firm statement about the past. Instead, he uses it to demonstrate how murky memory can be, and how foolish it is to trust that things are merely how they appear. In this way, he may have been asking readers and critics to take an equally nuanced approach to his and Plath's work—and to their real-life saga.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Ted Hughes and Sylvia Plath were one of the most high-profile literary couples of the 20th century, and their story continues to fascinate and disturb readers. They first met in 1956 in Cambridge, England. Plath was in England on a Fulbright Scholarship and had wanted to meet Hughes after reading his poetry. After an intense [first encounter](#), they embarked on a whirlwind romance and were married four months later. Initially, their marriage appeared happy and creatively fruitful. They supported each other's literary ambitions, and together they had two children, Frieda and Nicholas.

In 1962, Hughes had an affair. Plath had long struggled with

mental illness (she often styled her "bang[s]" to hide a scar from a previous suicide attempt), and the subsequent breakup of the marriage caused her great psychological pain and trauma. She had previously been mistreated under the care of a psychiatric hospital and dreaded being institutionalized again. She died by suicide in 1963; Hughes was devastated, writing to a friend that the rest of his life was now "posthumous."

But with the end of Plath's life came the beginning of decades of speculation about Hughes's indirect responsibility for her death. As Fay Bound Alberti [writes](#):

[Writers argue about whether Plath was](#) [...]

biologically prone to depression, abused by her husband; whether she benefitted or lost out by her creative relationship with Ted Hughes; whether she was loved by him, abandoned by him, killed by him. Some of these claims are easier to prove than others.

Many Plath readers blamed Hughes for her suicide; some of his readings were even disrupted by shouts of "murderer," and on one 1970s visit to Australia, he found a crowd waiting in protest. Hughes's character was further tainted by accusations that he, acting as Plath's literary executor, deliberately removed negative references to himself in Plath's most famous collection, *Ariel*. Hughes remained mostly silent on the subject until the publication of *Birthday Letters*.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poet's Life and Career](#) — The Poetry Foundation's biography of Ted Hughes. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/ted-hughes>)
- [An Introduction to Birthday Letters](#) — Read a British Library article on Hughes's final book of poems. (<https://www.bl.uk/20th-century-literature/articles/an-introduction-to-birthday-letters>)
- ["Fulbright Scholars" Manuscript Draft](#) — Browse the notebook drafts of various poems from *Birthday Letters*, including "Fulbright Scholars." (<https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/manuscript-drafts-of-fulbright-scholars-and-other-poems-from-the-birthday-letters-notebooks>)
- [A Portrait of Plath in Poetry](#) — A New York Times review of *Birthday Letters*. (<https://archive.nytimes.com/www.nytimes.com/books/98/02/08/daily/hughes-book-review.html>)
- ["Getting Over Sylvia Plath": Hughes Before and After Plath](#) — An Atlantic article discussing the overlap of Ted Hughes's and Sylvia Plath's work, and why it's important to consider Hughes's other influences.

(<https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2016/01/getting-over-sylvia-plath/419091/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER TED HUGHES POEMS

- [A Memory](#)
- [Anniversary](#)
- [A Picture of Otto](#)
- [Bayonet Charge](#)
- [Cat and Mouse](#)
- [Football at Slack](#)
- [Hawk Roosting](#)
- [Relic](#)
- [Roe-Deer](#)
- [Snowdrop](#)
- [Telegraph Wires](#)
- [The Harvest Moon](#)
- [The Horses](#)
- [The Jaguar](#)

- [The Other](#)
- [The Shot](#)
- [The Thought Fox](#)
- [Wind](#)



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